



Peter the Great's Academy of Sciences in St. Petersburg, founded in 1725, was rehoused in this building of 1783–85 on the Neva River.

## “YOU ARE NOW TRAVELING INTO THE PARADISE OF THE SCHOLARS.”

Caspar Wolff, German scientist, praising the Academy of Sciences in a letter to mathematician Leonhard Euler, c. 1779

### THE TREATY OF THE HAGUE

(see 1720) did not end rivalries between the major European powers. In 1725, Austria signed the **Treaty of Vienna** with Spain, gaining trading advantages in the colonies for its Imperial Ostend Company; in exchange, Austria abandoned all claims to the Spanish throne and also promised to help Spain recapture Gibraltar. In 1726, Britain embarked on an attempt to blockade Spanish treasure ships at Porto Bello,



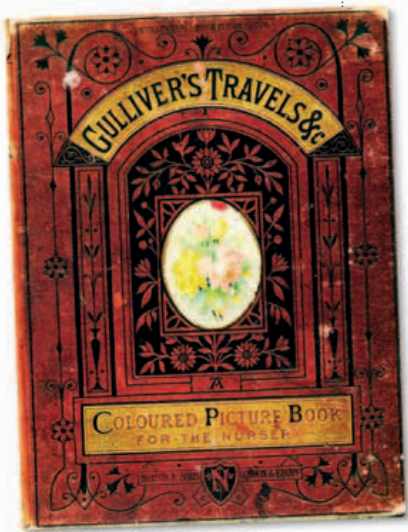
CATHERINE I (1684–1727)

The orphaned daughter of Lithuanian peasants, the future wife of Peter the Great was born Marta Skowrońska. She was secretly married to Peter in 1707, and she reigned as Russia's first female monarch from his death until her own. In her reign, she was supported by the Supreme Privy Council, which wanted to deny power to the aristocracy.

Panama, but withdrew without success in 1727 after severe losses from disease.

Emboldened by its promise of Austrian support, which was negated by a secret pact made between Britain and Austria, **Spain besieged Gibraltar** in 1727, an act that precipitated the **Anglo-Spanish War**. The four-month siege failed, costing Spain 1,400 men to British casualties of 300. The war ended with the Treaty of Seville in 1729.

In Russia, the **St. Petersburg Academy of Sciences** was founded in 1725 by Peter the Great (1672–1725). The most eminent scholars of all disciplines were invited to work there—for example, German embryologist Caspar Wolff (1733–94) offered Swiss mathematician Leonhard Euler a 200-rouble salary as an enticement, which he accepted.



To the southeast, the Afghan shah of Persia, Mahmud Hotaki (see 1721–22), died in 1725. He was succeeded by his cousin, Ashraf Khan (d. 1730), who may have murdered him. By then,

**Persian lands** were being encroached upon by **Ottoman forces**, who were linked to the previous regime by an **Ottoman-Safavid alliance**. However, Ashraf Khan defeated the Ottomans in a battle near Isfahan at Kermanshah, and peace was eventually declared at Hamadan, Persia, in 1727.

### Satirical novel

Clergyman and writer Jonathan Swift (1667–1745) first published Gulliver's Travels in 1726. This edition of the satire on humanity was published in the 1860s.

### Coffee in Brazil

This 19th-century woodcut shows a Brazilian coffee plantation. From small beginnings in 1727, Brazil grew into the world's largest coffee producer.

Also in 1727, the **Treaty of Kyakhta** was signed by **Imperial Russia** and the **Chinese Qing Empire**; it remained the basis of relations between the two until the mid-19th century. Mongolia's northern border was mapped and agreed on, and routes established for trade in furs and tea.

The late 1720s saw the start of **coffee-growing** in the Caribbean and South America. Seedlings were first brought to Martinique around 1720, and in 1727 the king of Portugal sent to French Guinea for seeds. His envoy, Francisco de Mello Palheta, persuaded the French governor's wife to provide seeds and seedlings, and these enabled the Portuguese to start a coffee industry in Brazil.



The Shinto gate (*torii*) at the entrance to the Itsukushima Shrine, Japan.

### THE RUSSIAN EMPEROR PETER THE GREAT

was determined to discover the full **extent of his lands to the east**. A Danish seaman, Vitus Bering (1681–1741), was commissioned to follow the Siberian coast northward from the Kamchatka Peninsula, and in 1728 **Bering** sailed into the narrow **strait**, now named after him, that **separates Siberia and Alaska**. By sailing farther north, Bering established that Siberia reaches its eastward limit at the strait. Bering suspected that there must be land farther east, but it was only during a second voyage, in 1741, that he first saw the coast of Alaska across the strait.

On the Indian subcontinent, the **Maratha** people, after nearly a decade of consolidating their power under Bajirao (see 1720), struck out into the Deccan region surrounding their homeland. In 1728, in the **Battle of Palkhed**, they confronted rival prince Asaf Jah I of Hyderabad (also known as Nizam-ul-Mulk) who had been laying claim to Maratha leadership and who was refusing to pay them *chauth* (a tribute tax). In a strategic masterstroke, the Marathas cornered the nizam's army in a waterless zone, where it refused to fight. In consequence, the nizam abandoned his leadership claim and payment of *chauth* was resumed.

The year 1729 was a pivotal point in **trading relations between China and the West** because the Qing Yongzheng emperor banned almost all

**January 28, 1725**  
Peter the Great  
dies. Catherine I  
continues work of founding  
his Academy of Sciences

**April 30, 1725**  
Austria and Spain  
sign Treaty of Vienna

**February 11, 1727**  
Spain begins siege of  
Gibraltar (to 12 June)

**August 23, 1727** Russia  
and China sign Treaty of  
Kyakhta in Mongolian  
border town

**February 28, 1728**  
Maratha defeat Asaf Jah I,  
ruler of Hyderabad, in  
Battle of Palkhed

**April 22, 1725** Afghan-born  
Shah Mahmud Hotaki of  
Persia (born c. 1697) dies  
or is murdered

**1726** Vast Chinese  
encyclopedia Gujin  
Tushu Jicheng printed  
using movable type

**1727** Portuguese  
introduce coffee to Brazil

**November 18, 1727**  
Foundation stone laid of  
new city of Jaipur, India

**May 18, 1728** Peter II  
crowned czar of Russia,  
succeeding Catherine I